



DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS
Office of Procurement, Acquisition and Logistics (OPAL)
Strategic Acquisition Center - Frederick (SAC-F)
5202 Presidents Ct, Suite 103
Frederick, MD 21703

**SOLE SOURCE JUSTIFICATION UNDER SIMPLIFIED PROCEDURES FOR
CERTAIN COMMERCIAL ITEMS IN ACCORDANCE WITH FEDERAL ACQUISITION
REGULATION (FAR) 13.5**

(1) Identification of the agency and contracting activity, and specific identification of the document as a “Sole Source Justification Under Simplified Procedures for Certain Commercial Items in Accordance with Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) 13.5.”

The Strategic Acquisition Center - Frederick (SAC-F), on behalf of the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA), Veterans Health Administration (VHA), Homeless Programs Office (HPO), proposes to enter into a sole source contract with ABT Global, LLC under simplified acquisition procedures.

(2) The nature and/or description of the action being approved, i.e., sole source under procedures for certain commercial items in accordance with FAR 13.5.

This Justification for Other than Full and Open Competition proposes to award a firm fixed price non-competitive award with ABT Global, LLC who is a Large Business located at 6130 Executive Blvd. Rockville, MD 20852. HPO has a crucial mandate under Section 309 of the Consolidated Appropriations Act of 2023. This mandate requires the establishment of an information-sharing system between Homeless Management Information System (HMIS) and Housing Operations, Management, and Evaluation System (HOMES) within three years of implementation. This legislative framework not only guides but also compels collaboration with Housing and Urban Development (HUD) to ensure timely and effective implementation within the specified timeline. It underscores the Government's unwavering commitment to enhancing services for homeless veterans through structured and coordinated efforts.

(3) A description of the supplies and/or services required, including the delivery schedule and/or the period of performance (inclusive of all option periods), and the estimated dollar value of the acquisition.

The VA requires a contractor to deliver comprehensive HMIS services, including an HMIS Boot Camp for VA Homeless Program Staff to enhance their proficiency in correctly utilizing the HMIS system, which is a database system used by community homeless service providers to collect and store data on individuals experiencing homelessness. Additionally, the contractor shall be responsible for ongoing HMIS Use/Disclosure Inventory Maintenance, creating a HUD VA Supportive Housing (VASH) HOMES to HMIS Data Transfer Tool (HVTT), maintaining an HMIS Dashboard for Homeless Programs Office staff, offering Business Intelligence (BI) Dashboard



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Consultation services, providing expert technical assistance to meet Cleland Dole legislative requirements, and delivering robust Data Analysis services to ensure compliance with the Strong Act. These specialized services are critical to support the VA's commitment to rapidly expand programs that prevent homelessness among Veterans and assist those currently experiencing homelessness. ABT Global, LLC has specialized knowledge and experience with HMIS systems that are directly related to these tasks outlined by Section 309 of the Consolidated Appropriations Act of 2023, Division U, Joseph Maxwell Cleland and Robert Joseph Dole Memorial Veterans Benefits and Health Care Improvement Act of 2022 (P.L. 117 328, 12/29/2022)

The period of performance for the proposed action is:

- Base Period: From date of award to 12 months after date of award.
- Option Period 1: From the end of the base year to 12 months after.
- Option Period 2: From the end of the Option Year 1 to 12 months after.
- Option Period 3: From the end of the Option Year 2 to 12 months after.
- Option Period 4: From the end of the Option Year 3 to 12 months after.

The anticipated contract will be a twelve (12) month base plus four (4) twelve (12) month option periods. The work started in the base period may be exercised at the discretion of the Government. The total estimated dollar value of this requirement, including all options is [REDACTED].

(4) The statutory authority permitting sole source.

This action is under the procedures of Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) 13.5 under the authority of:

☒ 41 U.S.C. 1901, Simplified Acquisition Procedures

☐ 41 U.S.C. 1903, Special Emergency Procurement Authority

This acquisition is conducted under the procedures of FAR subpart 13.5, used in accordance with the authority of 41 U.S.C § 1901. FAR 13.5 authorizes the use of Part 13 simplified procedures for certain commercial items. Acquisitions conducted under simplified acquisition procedures are exempt from the competition requirements listed in FAR Part 6. FAR 13.501(a)(1). Instead, Contracting Officers are required to promote competition to the maximum extent practicable. FAR 13.104. FAR Part 13 requires the agency to justify in writing sole source acquisitions. FAR 13.501(a)(1)(i). The agency may solicit from only one source if the circumstances of the contract action deem only one source reasonably available. FAR 13.106-1(b)(1)(i).



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(5) A statement demonstrating the unique qualifications of the proposed contractor or the nature of the action requiring use of the authority.

Expertise in Data Systems and Compliance:

ABT Global, LLC, possesses unique qualifications that make them the sole choice for this acquisition. Their expertise in data systems, particularly in the HMIS and the HOMES, is essential for the project at hand. ABT Global, LLC has a proven track record of managing sensitive Veteran data through HMIS systems, as a sub-contractor, and ensuring compliance with federal regulations specific to VA programs. HMIS implementations exist at the Continuum of Care (CoC) level and are used locally to collect information about people experiencing homelessness. ABT Global, LLC is the only firm with the technical expertise to ensure VA grantees upload HMIS information to the VA's repository to measure the extent of Veteran homelessness.

Moreover, ABT Global, LLC has extensive knowledge and expertise in managing data uploads to the VA data repository, which will be essential for implementing the requirements in the Cleland-Dole Act and Section 309 of the Consolidated Appropriations Act of 2023. The process to capture HMIS data for the purpose of uploading the VA Repository was created by and has been solely implemented by ABT Global, LLC staff since the inception of the Supportive Services for Veteran Families (SSVF) program and expanded to support Grant and Per Diem – Case Management (GPD-CM) to upload HMIS data to the VA's Repository beginning in 2023. Given ABT Global LLC's unparalleled experience with HMIS data uploads and the VA's Repository, no other vendor can match their capability to deliver these services. The VA Repository is written in Microsoft Structured Query Language (MS SQL) and can only be accessed by persons with two forms of identity clearance: a Personal Identity Verification (PIV) card and a National Marine Electronics Association (NMEA) account, both issued by a local VA Medical Center (VAMC) after extensive background checks and fingerprint analysis. Two of ABT Global, LLC staff have both levels of clearance, which take months to achieve, to provide redundancy and quality assurance for all data analyses. ABT Global, LLC has unique expertise in the technical and functional aspects of the Repository system, with the capacity to perform back-end coding support, provide full support for data uploads, manage technical changes, and monitor required program data from each VA grantee's HMIS to the VA's Repository. Utilizing ABT Global LLC's already cleared personnel is crucial to avoid several months of delay in starting the implementation of the required legislation, which has already experienced setbacks.

Establishing National Standards and Producing Reports:

For more than 20 years, ABT Global, LLC has been at the forefront of HUD's efforts to implement HMIS and to advance its data collection, reporting, and analysis efforts. ABT Global, LLC leads several HUD technical assistance (TA) data strategy and policy groups and provides real-time direct TA through the HUD Ask-A-Question (AAQ) help



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desk, responding to hundreds of questions about HMIS, the HUD Data Exchange (HDX) platforms, Housing Inventory Counts (HIC), Point-In-Time (PIT) Counts, System Performance Measures (SPM) reporting, and Longitudinal Systems Analysis (LSA) reporting. Since the inception and implementation of HMIS in 2004, ABT Global, LLC has led the development and modification of the HMIS Data Standards, the LSA specifications, and repository, the Comma Separated Values (CSV) specifications, the Xtensible Markup Language (XML) specifications, and varying products to help Continuums of Care (CoC) and HMIS Leads clean, synthesize, analyze, and apply data-driven system improvements to end homelessness. ABT Global, LLC has also led the discussion around standardizing data security and governance for HMIS, including producing the official HMIS security standards on behalf of HUD. Working with HUD, HMIS vendors, and HMIS System Administrators has been essential to ensure these specifications are up-to-date, operational, and responsive to multiple partner needs. The VA builds off of this extensive knowledge to keep the VA informed and a part of updated conversations.

Furthermore, ABT Global, LLC's qualifications extend to their previous work under an initial contract with HUD, where they established national data and technical standards for local HMIS and selected a nationally representative group of communities to participate. Subsequently, they continue to update the national data and technical standards for HMIS, conduct data analysis from around 400 communities nationwide, and have produced biannual Annual Homeless Assessment Report (AHAR) volumes. These reports offered comprehensive trend analyses at the national, state, and local levels, highlighting ABT Inc's proficiency in handling complex data systems and producing valuable insights.

Experience in Managing Data Systems and Developing Standards:

ABT Global, LLC's extensive experience and successful track record in managing data systems, developing standards, and producing insightful reports demonstrate their unique qualifications and suitability for the project requiring the use of Sole Source Justification authority. ABT Global, LLC is setting the industry standard in HMIS data repository work. There are no other entities currently engaged at this work at the Federal level, therefore all solutions and tools are unique to ABT. While other firms may have a tool or a system that enhances a community or organization's experience with HMIS, none are actively working on and supporting a repository at the Federal level, with simultaneous data uploads and data quality checks happening across all 50 States and several US territories. ABT Global, LLC TA staff are uniquely positioned to provide TA on both local systems as well as the VA HMIS Repository.

As an example of similar work, ABT Global, LLC's creation and modification of HUD's LSA Specifications have dramatically improved the consistency in reporting across HMIS software solutions and the quality of AHAR reporting. Access to the increased



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granularity of HMIS data in the first few years exposed data quality issues that had been previously unknown. ABT Global, LLC recent development of Eva and the use of integrated errors and warnings introduced as part of LSA has resulted in improvements in the quality of CoCs' local HMIS data as well. The HDX interface has eased the burden of uploading and submitting AHAR data in HDX 2.0. Similarly, CoCs are improving their PIT counts, especially on unsheltered homelessness, with ABT Global, LLC's new methodological guidance and tools published in 2016, 2018, 2021, and 2022 and updated annually ahead of PIT counts.

Examples of the products completed include:

- [Annual Homeless Assessment Reports \(AHAR\) to Congress](#), Parts 1 and 2 in 2007-2023. These reports provide our nation's best understanding of homelessness annually and on a single night.
- [LSA Specifications, LSA Data Dictionary, and Sample Code](#). These resources provide HMIS vendors assistance to accomplish the highly complex programming task. For some, the sample code can be "cut and pasted" for use with communities.
- [Homelessness Data Exchange \(HDX 2.0\)](#). Intuitive and easy to use, this site incorporates thousands of data quality validations and provides real-time feedback on thousands of data quality issues – both critical and noncritical – that exist within the tens of thousands of data elements included in the LSA report.
- [SPM Datasets \(2015-2021\)](#). These datasets provide HUD critical information on CoC progress on ending homelessness.
- [Stella Performance and Stella Modeling](#). Stella P provides dynamic visuals of CoCs' LSA data, which enables them to understand who and how households experiencing homelessness are using shelter and housing programs. Stella M allows CoCs to model various strategies to address homelessness to inform CoC planning and resource needs.
- [Eva](#). Eva is an open-source, web-based product built with R Shiny, to help CoCs assess the accuracy and completeness of their HMIS data and to identify organizations and projects struggling the most with data quality.

Failure to award this contract would result in the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) being non-compliant with the current legal requirements under Section 309 of the Cleland-Dole Act. This legislation mandates that the VA and HUD share data on Veterans experiencing homelessness.

Utilizing this data is crucial for the VA to accurately identify Veterans who are currently homeless within the community. At present, the VA's outreach efforts are limited to Veterans already known to the VA. For instance, a recent survey conducted by HPO in December 2024 revealed that the VA was tracking



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approximately 1,200 unsheltered Veterans. However, annual HUD point-in-time counts typically indicate that 13,851 or more Veterans are experiencing unsheltered homelessness.

If this contract is not awarded, the VA will lack visibility into the true number of Veterans experiencing unsheltered homelessness, severely hampering outreach activities. Consequently, this could potentially leave over 10,000 Veterans without shelter and without a pathway to permanent housing.

(6) A description of efforts made to ensure offers/quotes are solicited from as many potential sources as is practicable, including whether a notice was or will be publicized as required by FAR 5.2 and, if not, which exception under 5.202 applies.

A notice of intent to sole source synopsis was posted on System for Award Management (SAM.gov) on November 6, 2024, and was closed on November 13, 2024, two (2) responses were received from IS Holistic Solutions, LLC. and DTEC Software Solutions Private Limited. Further information regarding these responses is provided in (10) below.

(7) The anticipated dollar value of the proposed acquisition, including options if applicable, and a determination by the contracting officer that the anticipated cost to the government will be fair and reasonable.

The total estimated dollar value of this requirement, including all options is [REDACTED]. No award shall be made until the Contracting Officer determines the price to the Government to be fair and reasonable. This determination will be based on a comparison of the Independent Government Cost Estimate (IGCE), past proposal submissions (if available), and other information as made available.

(8) A description of the market research conducted and the results or the reason market research was not conducted.

On November 7, 2024, contracting searched Dynamic Small Business Search (DSBS), Federal Procurement Data System – Next Generation (FPDS), Veteran Small Business Certificate (VetCert), and General Services Administration (GSA) eLibrary using search criteria such as “Homeless Management Information Systems” and no results that resembled the service was available. SAM was searched and results found ABT Global, LLC as an active vendor with no active exclusions.

Contracting then searched online sources and found that ABT Global, LLC was the only establishment that offered these services. This requirement is not suitable for a set



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aside and shall be considered other than full and open competition. Contracting found that the required "expertise specialized data analysis and homeless management information system services" is only available through ABT Global, LLC and will continue to conduct market research to see if this changes in the future.

It is hereby determined based on the findings above that no SDVOSB, VOSB, SB, or GSA Schedule are technically capable of providing this requirement. As a result, the acquisition strategy most suitable for this requirement is a sole source requirement.

Thus, there were no SDVOSBs known to complete the work.

The market research conducted demonstrates the unique nature of the services available from ABT Global, LLC.

(9) Any other facts supporting the use of sole source.

ABT Global, LLC's extensive experience and expertise in providing national data support to both the HUD and the VA uniquely positions them to assist the VA in implementing legislation that mandates the establishment of data-sharing capabilities with HUD. Furthermore, ABT Global, LLC's proficiency in backend programming of the HMIS and their specialized knowledge of the VA's data repository are unparalleled. These specialized capabilities make ABT Global, LLC the only viable vendor for this critical initiative.

(10) A listing of the sources, if any, that expressed, in writing, an interest in the acquisition.

ABT Global, LLC
6130 Executive Blvd.
Rockville, MD 20852

IS Holistic Solutions, LLC
176 Clinton Ave
Albany, NY 12210

The first response is from IS Holistic Solutions, LLC, 176 Clinton Ave, Albany, NY 12210. The capability statement was evaluated for their capability to provide the specialized Homeless Management Information System (HMIS) services required by the VA. However, it has been determined that they are not equipped to meet the specific Government qualifications and expertise necessary for this project based on the following:.



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1. **HMIS Boot Camp Training:** The VA requires the ability to conduct HMIS Boot Camp training for VA Homeless Program Staff. IS Holistic Solutions lacks the experience and qualifications to deliver this specialized training effectively.
2. **HMIS Use/Disclosure Inventory Maintenance:** Expertise in ongoing HMIS Use/Disclosure Inventory Maintenance is essential. IS Holistic Solutions does not have the necessary background in maintaining these critical inventories.
3. **Development of HUD VASH HOMES to HMIS Data Transfer Tool (HVTT):** The development capabilities for creating a HUD VASH HOMES to HMIS Data Transfer Tool (HVTT) are crucial. IS Holistic Solutions does not possess the technical expertise required for this development.
4. **HMIS Dashboard Maintenance:** Proficient maintenance of an HMIS Dashboard for Homeless Programs Office staff is a key requirement. IS Holistic Solutions lacks the experience in maintaining such dashboards.
5. **BI Dashboard Implementation Consultation:** Consultation services for BI Dashboard implementation are needed. IS Holistic Solutions does not have the specialized knowledge to provide effective consultation in this area.
6. **Specialized Technical Assistance:** The VA requires specialized technical assistance to meet legislative requirements outlined in recent acts such as the Cleland Dole legislation. IS Holistic Solutions does not have the advanced data analysis capabilities required to ensure compliance with these federal mandates.
7. **Advanced Data Analysis and Compliance:** Advanced data analysis capabilities are necessary to ensure compliance with federal mandates like the Strong Act. IS Holistic Solutions does not have the requisite experience in managing sensitive data within HMIS systems and ensuring adherence to federal regulations specific to VA programs.

These tasks are highly specialized, necessitating a contractor with an established track record of managing sensitive data within HMIS systems and ensuring adherence to federal regulations specific to VA programs. The need for such a high level of specialization stems from recent legislative mandates which have set forth new standards and requirements for managing veteran homelessness programs. These standards demand not only proficiency in current HMIS use but also innovation and development of new tools and methodologies that can interface seamlessly with existing government databases while ensuring data quality and security.



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Given these highly specified needs, IS Holistic Solutions does not have the requisite experience or qualifications necessary to deliver on such intricate service requirements that support the VA's efforts against Veteran homelessness.

DTEC Software Solutions Private Limited
Mahadevikadu PO, Karthikapally
Alappuzha, Kerala, India, 690516

The second response is from DTEC Software Solutions Private Limited, Mahadevikadu PO, Karthikapally, Alappuzha, Kerala, India, 690516. DTEC Software Solutions has been evaluated for their capability to provide the necessary services for the Government's project. However, it has been determined that they are unable to meet the essential Government requirements due to a lack of experience and expertise in several critical areas as follows:

1. **Lack of Experience with HMIS and HOMES:** DTEC Software Solutions does not possess any experience with the Homeless Management Information System (HMIS) and the Housing Operations, Management, and Evaluation System (HOMES). These systems are fundamental to the project's success, and proficiency in these areas is non-negotiable.
2. **Inadequate Knowledge of VA Data Repository Management:** The project requires managing data uploads to the VA data repository, a crucial component for implementing the Cleland-Dole Act and Section 309 of the Consolidated Appropriations Act of 2023. DTEC Software Solutions lacks the necessary knowledge and expertise in this area.
3. **No Expertise in VHA Homeless Programs:** The vendor does not have any knowledge or expertise in VHA Homeless Programs, which is essential for understanding and addressing the specific needs of the project.
4. **Access and Security Clearance Issues:** The VA Repository is written in MS SQL and requires access by individuals with two forms of identity clearance: a PIV card and an NMEA account. These are issued by a local VA Medical Center (VAMC) after extensive background checks and fingerprint analysis, a process that takes several months. DTEC Software Solutions does not currently have personnel who have undergone these background checks, making the process to access the repository would require a significant amount of time.

Given these significant gaps in experience, knowledge, and security clearances, DTEC Software Solutions is not in a position to meet the specific needs of the Government's project. It is essential to select a vendor that is already cleared through the necessary



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background checks and has proven expertise in HMIS, HOMES, and VHA Homeless Programs to ensure the project's success and compliance with legislative requirements.

(11) A statement of the actions, if any, the agency may take to remove or overcome any barriers to competition before any subsequent acquisition for the supplies or services required.

In future acquisitions, appropriate market research will be conducted to determine if sources capable of meeting the agency's needs have become available in the marketplace.

(12) Evidence that any supporting data that is the responsibility of technical or requirements personnel (e.g., verifying the Government's minimum needs or requirements or other rationale for an exception to fair opportunity) and which form a basis for the justification have been certified as complete and accurate by the technical or requirements personnel.

I certify that the supporting data under my cognizance, which are included in this justification, are accurate and complete to the best of my knowledge and belief.

Signature: NICOLE JOSEPH Digitally signed by
NICOLE JOSEPH
Date: 2025.01.03
06:17:27 -08'00' Date: 01/03/2025

Nicole Joseph
Executive Administrative Officer
Office of the Executive Director



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(13) Contracting officer certification that the justification is accurate and complete to the best of the contracting officer's knowledge and belief.

Contracting Officer:

Pursuant to FAR 6.303-2(a)(12), I certify that this justification is accurate and complete to the best of my knowledge and belief.

Signature: DYLAN NOLZ Digitally signed by DYLAN NOLZ
Date: 2025.01.03
09:26:20 -05'00' Date: 01/03/2025

Dylan Nolz
Contracting Officer
Strategic Acquisition Center- Frederick (SAC-F)



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Approval

In my role as Contracting Activity Competition Advocate, based on the foregoing justification, I hereby approve this acquisition on an “other than full and open competition” basis pursuant to the statutory authority cited in paragraph four above, subject to availability of funds, and provided that the property and services herein described have otherwise been authorized for acquisition. As this action does not exceed \$15M, the certification below required by FAR 13.501(a)(2)(ii) serves as approval.

Signature: EFRAIN FERNANDEZ Digitally signed by EFRAIN FERNANDEZ
Date: 2025.01.07
09:08:13 -05'00' Date: _____
Efrain J. Fernandez
Director of Contracts, Acquisition Services 1-3
Procuring Activity Advocate for Competition –(SAC-Frederick)
Strategic Acquisition Center
Tracking Number: 25F-0045a